

MATH40002 - Analysis I

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More details at <https://stones-y.github.io>.

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Chapter 1

Numbers and Sets

1.1 Introduction

In the introductory module (MATH40001), we constructed the number systems $\mathbb{N}$, $\mathbb{Z}$, $\mathbb{Q}$ and $\mathbb{R}$. Real analysis focuses on the real numbers, $\mathbb{R}$, formalising many properties about functions that we know from calculus. For example, an intuitive notion of a continuous function is that you can draw the function on a piece of paper without taking your pen off the page. We make concepts like these precise in this module.

1.2 Countability

Before starting this chapter (and, in general, this module), it is imperative that you are familiar with the logic and sets part of the introductory module, MATH40001.

Definition 1.1. A set A is countably infinite if there exists a bijection $f : \mathbb{N} \rightarrow A$.

The idea is that you can list the elements of A as $a_1, a_2, \dots$ using only the natural numbers. We say that a set is *countable* if it is finite or countably infinite. Note we will take $\mathbb{N} = \{0, 1, 2, \dots\}$.

Theorem 1.2. If $A \subseteq \mathbb{N}$ is an infinite set, then A is countably infinite.

Proof. We construct a function $f : \mathbb{N} \rightarrow A$ inductively: since A is nonempty, and $A \subseteq \mathbb{N}$, by well-ordering of the natural numbers we can pick $a_1 = \min A$, and let $f(1) = a_1$. Assume that, for $k \geq 1$, $a_1, \dots, a_k$ have been chosen and $f(i) = a_i$ for $1 \leq i \leq k$. Since A is infinite, $A \setminus \{a_1, \dots, a_k\}$ is nonempty. Pick $a_{k+1} = \min(A \setminus \{a_1, \dots, a_k\})$, and let $f(k+1) = a_{k+1}$. Thus by construction f is strictly increasing. We claim that f is a bijection.

- Injective: this holds because by construction f is strictly increasing. We saw in the introductory module that strictly increasing functions are injective.
- Surjective: suppose for contradiction that f is not surjective. Then there exists $a \in A$ such that for all $n \in \mathbb{N}$, $f(n) \neq a$. Consider $A \setminus \{a\}$.

□

Lemma 1.3. Let S be an infinite set. There exists an injection $f : \mathbb{N} \rightarrow S$.

Proof. We construct a function $f : \mathbb{N} \rightarrow S$ inductively: since S is infinite, it is nonempty, so we can pick $s_1 \in S$ and define $f(1) := s_1$. Suppose for $k \in \mathbb{N}$, $s_1, \dots, s_k$ have been chosen and we have defined $f(i) = s_i$ for $1 \leq i \leq k$. Since S is infinite, $S \setminus \{s_1, \dots, s_k\}$ is nonempty, so there is $s_{k+1} \in S \setminus \{s_1, \dots, s_k\}$. Define $f(k+1) := s_{k+1}$. By construction, if $i < j$ are natural numbers, then $s_j \in S \setminus \{s_1, \dots, s_{j-1}\}$ so $s_j \neq s_i$. So f is an injection. $\square$

The idea for the above theorem is that we can always *embed* the natural numbers into any infinite set via an injection $f : \mathbb{N} \rightarrow S$ (where S is any infinite set). In this way, the natural numbers can be thought of as 'the smallest type of infinity'.

A not so surprising fact which we can immediately prove is that the set of integers, $\mathbb{Z}$, is countably infinite:

Theorem 1.4. $\mathbb{Z}$ is countably infinite.

Proof. Define $f : \mathbb{N} \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}$ by

$$f(n) = \begin{cases} n/2, & n \text{ even} \\ -\frac{(n+1)}{2}, & n \text{ odd} \end{cases}$$

Then f is injective: suppose $f(a) = f(b)$. If a and b are of different parity then $f(a)$ and $f(b)$ are of different sign, so cannot be equal. So this case cannot happen. If a and b are even, then $a/2 = b/2$ so $a = b$. If a and b are odd, then $-(a+1)/2 = -(b+1)/2$ so $a = b$. So f is injective. Also, f is surjective: let $m \in \mathbb{Z}$ be arbitrary. If $m < 0$ then $f(-2m-1) = m$, and if $m \geq 0$ then $f(2m) = m$. Thus f is a bijection and $\mathbb{Z}$ is countable. $\square$

Remark. This proof used a useful trick called interleaving, where we listed the integers as $0, -1, 1, -2, 2, \dots$, interleaving the negative and positive integers to create the desired bijection between $\mathbb{N}$ and $\mathbb{Z}$.

A less trivial fact is that the rational numbers, $\mathbb{Q}$, is countable. This may be hard to see until observing the proof of the following fact:

Theorem 1.5. $\mathbb{N}^2$ is countably infinite.

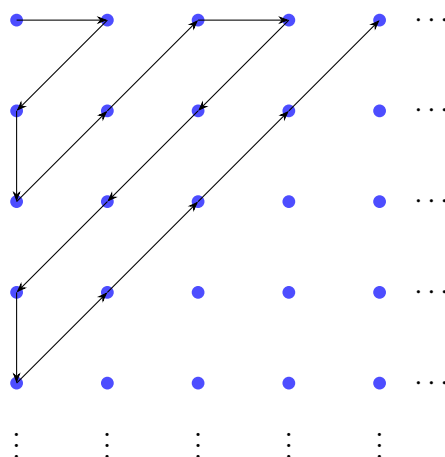


Figure 1.1: The diagonal listing of $\mathbb{N}^2$, showing it is countably infinite.

Proof. The idea is illustrated in the above diagram. Note that the listing goes

$$(0, 0), (0, 1), (1, 0), (2, 0), (1, 1), (0, 2), \dots$$

Notice that along each diagonal, $a + b$ is constant for all pairs (a, b) in that diagonal. This, along with the triangular number formula, provides the motivation for how to construct a bijection between $\mathbb{N}^2$ and $\mathbb{N}$.

Explicitly, define $f : \mathbb{N}^2 \rightarrow \mathbb{N}$ by $f(a, b) = \frac{(a+b)(a+b+1)}{2} + b$. This is a bijection (exercise) so $\mathbb{N}^2$ is countable. $\square$

As a consequence, we get:

Theorem 1.6. *$\mathbb{Q}$ is countably infinite.*

Proof. First we use Theorem 1.5 to show that $\mathbb{Q}_{\geq 0} := \{x \in \mathbb{Q} : x \geq 0\}$ is countably infinite. Let

$$S = \{(a, b) \in \mathbb{N}^2 : b \geq 1, \gcd(a, b) = 1\}.$$

Then $f : S \rightarrow \mathbb{Q}_{\geq 0}$, defined by $f(a, b) = a/b$ is a bijection because we know that all rational numbers in $\mathbb{Q}_{\geq 0}$ take the unique form a/b where $b \geq 1$ and $\gcd(a, b) = 1$. Since $\mathbb{N}^2$ is countably infinite by Theorem 1.5, $S \subseteq \mathbb{N}^2$ is also countably infinite, so $\mathbb{Q}_{\geq 0}$ is countably infinite.

It follows (exercise) that $\mathbb{Q}$ is countably infinite, using the same idea (interleaving) as the proof that $\mathbb{Z}$ is countably infinite. $\square$

Exercise. Finish the proof of Theorem 1.6. (*Hint: use the fact that, by Theorem 1.6, there exists a bijection $h : \mathbb{N} \rightarrow \mathbb{Q}_{\geq 0}$.*)